

SPRING 2023 | MW 10:15-11:30am | Levine Science Research Center (LSRC) Room D243

POLISCI 335S

Political, Social and Economic Institutions

a.k.a. “Understanding Institutions to Change the World”

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Course Overview

This course is an undergraduate seminar that will introduce you to institutions in the social, economic and political worlds; where those institutions come from; how they operate; why they persist and why they change. The course will focus on understanding particular examples of institutions—from prison gangs in the US to stable democracy to female footbinding. Occasionally during the course we’ll pause from studying specific institutions. During these interludes we’ll build from our knowledge of individual institutions to incorporate theories about big questions like *what* exactly an institution is, why and how institutions originate, and the process by which institutions change or stay the same.

Because institutions are powerful forces that shape human behavior—and thus have a large role to play in problems that exist in the world as well as

potential solutions—in this course we will also approach institutions from the perspective of social entrepreneurs. Students will develop a project in which they identify a problem in the world that they would like to solve. These problems can be in any realm of social, political or economic life. They can be big problems dealing with international relations, or small problems specific to one community. They can be domestic, or they can be international. What matters is that it's a problem that matters to you.

With careful guidance through sequenced assignments, students will identify the institutional context of that problem—including the relevant actors and their behaviors and their incentives—and devise a plan to change that institution to solve their problem. As with any real-world problem, the feasibility of students' plan for institutional change may be challenging. But in encountering those barriers, students will gain a new perspective on how the world works, and a greater ability to affect change, even if doing so is difficult.

It's important to be aware that we will cover topics in this course that are very sensitive and others that are highly personal. We'll work hard to cultivate a classroom environment that allows our discussions of these topics to be safe and open. It's important to recognize too that we take a social scientific approach to studying these sensitive and personal topics; which may be quite different from the approach that you're used to. To succeed in class, you must be willing to learn about the perspective a social scientist takes.

Big Ideas of the Course

This course is built on a small set of core **big ideas** and **enduring understandings** that shape our approach to materials and choice of topics and assignments.

The first big idea is that *institutions shape our behavior*. Whether we realize it or not, institutions shape our behavior and the behavior of those around us. When we want to know *why* someone is doing something, we often look for individual-specific rationales. But in this course we'll see how the behavior of individuals exists within a context of others' behavior. Many motivations that we think are unique to the individual are in fact deeply shaped by incentives created by the behavior of others. For students from Western cultures that emphasize individual autonomy and agency, it can be quite disconcerting—though also quite powerful—to see individual behavior in this new framework.

The second big idea is that *institutions are everywhere*. Not only is our behavior shaped by institutions, but this is a *constant occurrence*. We are rarely—if ever—free from institutions. Instead, it is more likely than not that in a given area of your life *multiple* institutions are layered upon one another, shaping your behavior and that of others. This big idea will allow you to begin to see these institutional layers throughout your life and the lives of others.

The third big idea in the course is that *institutions tend to persist and are not easily changed*. That is, institutions are rarely ephemeral constructs that spring into being only to disappear quickly thereafter. Instead, they have a tendency to shape behavior in a particular way over a very long period of time. In the course, we'll work to understand why exactly that is. If institutions change at all, it is often a slow drift, or evolution, rather than a sharp rupture. Nevertheless, institutions *can* and *do* change. And in this course we'll learn the processes by which this can happen.

Together, the above big ideas will allow us to understand that *affecting change in the world* requires *an understanding of the institutional contexts in which people operate*, and may in turn require *changing existing institutions*.

Course Structure

The course is structured as a seminar in which we discuss readings, ask questions, and probe topics of interest.

Organization

The course is organized around examples of particular types of institutions. As we learn about individual examples of institutions, we'll begin to see patterns in what constitutes an institution, how institutions work, where institutions come from, and when and why institutions evolve or change. At various points in the course, we will pause for theoretical *interludes* during which we take a step back from individual institutions to examine a bigger theoretical and conceptual picture. Because we approach these interludes armed with a understanding of individual institutions, my hope is that these treatments of topics like definitions of institutions or theories of institutional change will not be

hopelessly abstract, but will instead feel grounded in the real world.

Discussion

Individual class sessions will be discussion-based with only limited lecturing. In-class activities—both individual and with your peers—will also form an important component of *how* we learn material in class. As a consequence, deeply thoughtful and engaged participation, as discussed below, will be an absolutely essential component of class.

Readings

There is no textbook for the course. Instead, we will read papers and selected book chapters. There may also be additional media that are classified as “readings.” **All readings will be available on the course website on Sakai.** Readings will be under the relevant week’s folder, labeled with the week (W1, W2, etc.), labeled with the the class (C1 is on Wednesday, and C2 is on Friday). Readings should be completed before class.

Watching *The Wire*

The Wire is “really about the American city, and about how we live together. It’s about how institutions have an effect on individuals, and how, regardless of what you are committed to, whether you’re a cop, a longshoremen, a drug dealer, a politician, a judge, a lawyer, you are ultimately compromised and must contend with whatever institution you’ve committed to.”

—David Simon, creator
of *The Wire*, 2004

Outside of class, you will watch episodes of the first season of the HBO series *The Wire*. *The Wire* is a fictional show set in Baltimore in the early 2000s. Although *The Wire* is fictional, it is arguably one of the best treatments of local political, social and economic institutions in the US. The ability of the show to give you access to the stories of groups that you wouldn’t otherwise have access to at times and places that you wouldn’t otherwise have access to makes it a great learning resource. **The Wire is available for free through a Warpwire link on the Sakai site.**

Learning Goals

By the end of the course, you will be able to

1. Offer your own working definition of what an institution is, and be able to compare and contrast different definitions.
2. Identify institutions in your (and others') everyday lives.
3. For a given institution, be able to identify the actors involved in the institution, the behavioral choices that individuals can hypothetically make, the individual incentives that sustain the institution, and the regularity of behavioral outcome(s) that are produced.
4. Describe theories of where institutions originate and how, and apply those theories to better understand specific institutions.
5. Describe theories for how institutions change, explain why institutions tend *not* to change, and apply those theories to understand the persistence and change of specific institutions.
6. Analyze information relevant to a real-world problem, exclude information extraneous to that problem, and think logically and systematically about a specific solution to that problem from the perspective of an institution.

Assignments

A core goal of this course is for you to apply your understanding of institutions to a problem that you care about and to become a social entrepreneur in the institutional realm. To do so, the main assignments for the course will build towards a final project in which you analyze an existing institution, design a new one, and propose a means of institutional change. We will discuss additional details of all of the assignments listed below during the term.

Participation, including Reading Worksheets (25%)

We enrich our understanding of material by engaging with it together; learning from the insights of others; and forcing ourselves to question and respond when others have different understandings. Therefore, a significant portion of your grade will depend on whether you have completed the reading and assignments, your willingness to engage fully in any activities, and your ability to both offer quality contributions to discussion, and listen and actively engage with the contributions of your fellow classmates.

As a reference point, simply attending every ‘class’ merits a C grade. No joke. Simply saying one thing per class in addition, really isn’t much better. This should give you a clear indication that I have extremely high expectations for participation.

At the midway point in class, I will ask you to email me with the participation grade that you think, based on how you have participated up to that point, you deserve to receive. This gives you an opportunity to reflect on your own participation and the expectations of the class; not to simply be told how you are doing. However, I will respond to your email with information about your progress in this realm, and what you can do to improve.

Worksheets: One third of your 25% participation grade will be determined by completing reading worksheets. For each set of readings, there will be a short associated worksheet to guide your reading and to help you evaluate whether you are understanding what you are reading. The worksheets are to be completed **before** the class in which we discuss the readings. Worksheets ask you to answer questions about relatively basic reading comprehension, not provide in-depth analysis. As a result, expectations are for accurate but concise answers.

I will randomly grade your worksheets. At the beginning of each class, I’ll flip a coin—heads, I will grade what you turned in; tails, I won’t. Worksheets that indicate careful reading of the assigned texts will receive full marks (A), even if there are some minor errors. Worksheets that are incomplete or contain significant errors will receive a C. Worksheets that are not turned in or display no engagement with the assignment texts will receive a D. I will average your worksheet grades as part of your final participate grade.

Identifying Your Problem of Interest (5%)

DUE: Wednesday, February 8 (via Sakai)

This first assignment in the sequence that will culminate in your final project asks you to identify a problem in the world that you would like to solve. While some problems may be easier to use for this assignment than others, the only

real constraint is that the problem is something you care about solving. We will discuss additional details of the assignment in class.

The Institutions in Your Life (20%)

DUE: Wednesday, February 22 (via Sakai)

This is an ethnographic assignment in which I ask you to observe the institutions in your life, or, if that is too personal, the life of someone close to you. For three days to a week, I'd like you to keep a journal in which you note the institutions that are present in your life and how you see those institutions shaping your behavior or the behavior of others that you are observing. This does not need to be a formal essay in format; instead, a bullet point for each institution with a few sentence description of it and the relevant behaviors is fine.

We'll talk more about observational strategies for this assignment, but broadly you can approach this journal by (1) noting behaviors that you see and ask why those behaviors occur (i.e. which institutions shape those behaviors); (2) noting traditional definitions of institutions (i.e. "the university" or "the family") and ask how those institutions are operating in your life or the lives of others; or (3) thinking of basic problems of humans living together in groups and ask where you see those problems and where you don't and whether institutions have a role to play. As we'll learn in class, institutions can be hard to define and sometimes hard to see. So, the goal of the assignment is not to be *correct* or *complete* in listing institutions and their associated behaviors—there is no such thing. Instead, I'm interested in your deep and thoughtful exploration of institutions in your life.

A key to this assignment will be your ability not just to live in your life, but to cast critical eye on what you do and why. Questioning the most basic things you do and choices you make will open up new perspectives on where institutions are and how they operate. We will discuss additional details of the assignment in class, and we'll share our ethnographies with our classmates.

Presentation and Leading Class Discussion (15%)

DUE: To be determined

During the first few weeks of class, I will lead our class discussions. However, once you've gotten a feel for how these discussions go, I will ask each student to lead class on a particular institution and its associated readings. This will allow you to gain a deeper knowledge of the institution we study that day because *teaching* always requires deeper knowledge. To accomplish this, students will produce a brief (no more than 8 minute) presentation of a week's

reading, and lead class discussion after.

The Institutional Context of the Problem (15%)

DUE: Wednesday, March 29 (via Sakai)

In this assignment you will work from the problem that you identified in a previous assignment (or a revised version of the problem; you don't have to keep the same one), and the institution related to that problem. You will write a short essay about who the actors are that are involved in your institution. You will describe what their behaviors are and what their incentives are. You'll research where your institution came from—what its origins are—and how it has evolved (if at all) over time. I expect this assignment to be about 3 pages, double spaced, but longer essays are probably fine. We will discuss additional details of the assignment in class.

Final Institutional Design Project (20%)

DUE: Friday, May 5 at noon (via Sakai)

The final assignment for the course will ask you to put together previous assignments that you've worked on into a coherent whole. In an essay, you will write about the problem you see in the world, the details of the institutional context of that problem, the origins and evolution of the relevant institution, your plan for affecting change in the institution to help solve your problem, and the relative feasibility or difficulty of doing so. The last two pieces are new to this assignment. Your essay will be evaluated in part on your incorporation of feedback on prior building-block assignments. We will discuss additional details of the assignment in class.

Late Assignments

I expect assignments to be turned in on time. Assignments are due at the beginning of class on the assigned date, unless otherwise specified. Assignments will lose 1/3 of a letter grade (e.g. an assignment otherwise graded a B+ will be graded a B) for each 24 hours they are late unless we discuss in advance.

I understand, however, that life happens, and even when we have the best of intentions, unexpected things can happen, or we can fall behind and need a little help and compassion. If you are struggling to complete a given assignment on time, please reach out **before the due date**, if at all possible, to discuss how to complete the assignment in a way that won't affect in-class

activities or snow-ball into further late assignments.

I will give you **one 48 hour grace period (extension) for one assignment during the term**. That is, you can turn in one assignment up to 48 hours late without consequence. Because of grade due submission deadlines, you cannot use this grace period on the final assignment. This grace period is also not relevant for reading worksheets.

Grading

Letter grades will follow the standard format:

98-100 A+	88-80.9 B+	78-79.9 C+	60-70 D
93-97.9 A	83-87.9 B	73-77.9 C	below 60 D
90-92.9 A-	80-82.9 B-	70-72.9 C-	

Cultivating a Growth Mindset

With all marks—whether on individual assignments or in the course overall—I strongly encourage you take a growth mindset. A growth mindset requires that you believe that your abilities are not fixed based on some immutable notion of intelligence or talent, but are instead under your control to develop and improve through dedication and hard work. If you receive a top mark, this doesn't mean that there isn't more to do and more to learn. Similarly, if you receive a low mark, this is not a referendum on your intelligence or your potential. Instead, it is constructive feedback that is designed to help you to do better in the future.

Communication

I will use email—both independently and through Sakai—to communicate with you outside of class. **I expect that you will check your email regularly and respond promptly (within 24 hours of receipt of an personally-addressed email that requires your action or acknowledgement).**

Relatedly, please email me to communicate about any class topics. I pledge

to respond to your email within 24 hours of receipt. Therefore, if you have a time-sensitive question related to a deadline, please plan ahead and ask your question with enough time for me to respond.

Resources

Appointments with Me

I am happy to chat with students in person and via Zoom about course materials, their projects, or academic topics more broadly. If you have a question or comment that can be addressed quickly by email, you are welcome to pose it in that format as well. Please check the most updated version of the syllabus before reaching out about a course policy.

Your Fellow Students

I encourage you to view your fellow students as people you can learn from *as much* as your instructor. Your fellow students are a resource not only when you are in class, but outside of class as well. While you *must* complete your own work for class assignments, you are encouraged to get feedback from students in class (or beyond, for that matter).

Mental Health

Good mental health is as important as time management and good study habits to your success, not only as a student, but in life more generally. Duke has resources that can help you learn skills to manage anxiety, stress, and more serious mental health problems. Please visit the Duke Wellness Center in person or online to find out more. I am also very happy to direct you to resources in person.

The Library

The library is not only a repository of books, periodicals, journals and other media. It also has *people* who are excited to help students with their projects. Reference librarians are one of the great untapped resources at undergraduate institutions. If there is information that would help with your project and you aren't sure how to obtain it, talk with a reference librarian.

Honor Code

Duke is a community dedicated to scholarship, leadership, and service and to the principles of honesty, fairness, respect, and accountability. Citizens of this community commit to reflect upon and uphold these principles in all academic and nonacademic endeavors, and to protect and promote a culture of integrity.

To uphold the Duke Community Standard:

1. I will not lie, cheat, or steal in my academic endeavors;
2. I will conduct myself honorably in all my endeavors; and
3. I will act if the Standard is compromised.

For more on the Duke Community Standard, please visit:

<https://studentaffairs.duke.edu/conduct/about-us/duke-community-standard>.

Disability Accommodations

Students with disabilities have specific rights to be provided reasonable, necessary, and appropriate accommodations and have equal access to all programs and activities. If you require any accommodation for a disability and do not yet have formal documentation, please contact the Student Disability Access Office. If, or when, you have formal document for your accommodation, please provide that to me so that I can comply with your accommodations.

SCHEDULE OVERVIEW

Week	Session Type	Class	Topic	Exams/Assignments
1		W 1/11	Introduction	
2		M 1/16	** MLK Holiday (No Class) **	
2	Ex. Institution	W 1/18	Cooperation	
3	Ex. Institution	M 1/23	The State	
3	Ex. Institution	W 1/25	Prison Gangs	
4	The Wire	M 1/30	Episode 1-4 Discussion	
4	Theory	W 2/1	Defining Institutions: Rules	
5	Theory	M 2/6	Defining Institutions: Norms	Your Problem of Interest
5	Workshop	W 2/8	In-Class Discussion	
6	Ex. Institution	M 2/13	Democracy	
6	Ex. Institution	W 2/15	Judicial Review	
7		M 2/20	** Assignment Work Day (No Class) **	Institutions in Your Life
7	Workshop	W 2/22	In-Class Discussion	
8	Ex. Institution	M 2/27	Sicilian Mafia	
8	Ex. Institution	W 3/1	Car-Parking	
9	Theory	M 3/6	Institutional Origins: Emergence	
9	Theory	W 3/8	Institutional Origins: Design	
10		M 3/13	** Spring Break (No Class) **	
10		W 3/15	** Spring Break (No Class) **	
11	Ex. Institution*	M 3/20	Footbinding & FGM	
11	Ex. Institution*	W 3/22	Marriage	
12	Ex. Institution*	M 3/27	Peace Agreements	The Institutional Context
12		W 3/29	In-Class Discussion	
13	The Wire	M 4/3	Episodes 5-8	
13	Theory	W 4/5	Institutional Change	
14	Theory	M 4/10	Norm Change	
14		W 4/12	** Mental Health Day (No Class) **	
15	Ex. Institution*	M 4/17	Capitalist China	
15	Ex. Institution*	W 4/19	Corruption	
16	Ex. Institution*	M 4/24	The ICC	
16	The Wire	W 4/26	Episodes 9-13	
	Friday, 5/5 at noon			Final Paper

*denotes student presentation day

SCHEDULE DETAIL

Week 1

Class 1 (Wednesday)—January 11—Your Starting Understanding of Institutions

Week 2

Class 1—January 16—**MLK Holiday** (**NO CLASS**)

Class 2—January 18—Evolutionary Building Blocks of Cooperation

1. Harari, Yuval Noah (2015). *Sapiens*. New York: Harper Collins. **Pages 21-39.**
2. Fukuyama, Francis (2011). *The Origins of Political Order*. New York: Farrar Strauss and Giroux. **Chapter 2.**

Week 3

Class 1—January 23—The State

1. Bates, Robert H. (2001). *Prosperity and Violence*. New York: WW Norton. **Chapters 1-3.**

Class 2—January 25—Prison Gangs

1. Skarbek, Dave (2011). “Governance and Prison Gangs.” *American Political Science Review*. Vol. 105, No. 4.

Week 4

Class 1—January 30—Discussing *The Wire*, Episodes 1-4

1. Watch Season 1, Episodes 1-4 of *The Wire* by today.
2. No readings.

Class 2—February 1—Defining Institutions: Rules, Equilibria, Or?

1. North, Douglass (1990). *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance*. New York: Cambridge University Press. (**Pages 3-6.**)
2. Greif, Avner (2006). *Institutions and the Path to the Modern Economy: Lessons from Medieval Trade*. New York: Cambridge University Press. (**Section 2.1**)
3. Hodgson, Gregory (2006). “What are institutions?” *Journal of Economic Issues*. Vol XL, No 1.

Week 5

Class 1—February 6—Defining Institutions: Norms

1. Bicchieri, Cristina (2017). *Norms in the Wild: How to Diagnose, Measure and Change Social Norms*. New York: Oxford University Press.
Chapter 1.

Class 2—February 8—In-Class Workshop: Defining Your Problem

1. **DUE:** Identifying the Problem Assignment
2. No readings.

Week 6

Class 1—February 13—Creating a Sustainable Democracy

1. Mittal, Sonia and Barry Weingast (2013). "Self-Enforcing Constitutions: With an Application to Democratic Stability In America's First Century." *Journal of Law, Economics & Organization* Vol. 29 No. 2.

Class 2—February 15—Judicial Review

1. More Perfect (1 July 2016). "Kittens Kick The Giggly Blue Robot All Summer." Podcast. URL: <https://www.stitcher.com/podcast/wnyc/radiolab-presents-more-perfect/e/kittens-kick-the-giggly-blue-robot-all-summer-45172985>
2. Knight, Jack and Lee Epstein (1996). "On the Struggle for Judicial Supremacy." *Law & Society Review*.

Week 7

Class 1—February 20—Assignment Work Day (**NO CLASS**)

Class 2—February 22—In Class Discussion: Institutions in Your Life

1. **DUE:** The Institutions in Your Life Assignment
2. No readings

Week 8

Class 1—February 27—The Sicilian Mafia

1. Gambetta, Diego (1993). *The Sicilian Mafia: The Business of Private Protection*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press. **Selections.**

Class 2—March 1—Leaving Your Car with Strangers

1. Blajer de la Garza, Yuna (2019). “Leaving Your Car with Strangers: Informal Car Parkers and Improbable Trust in Mexico City” *Politics & Society*, Vol. 47 No. 3.

Week 9

Class 1—March 6—Institutional Origins: Emergence

1. Knight, Jack. “Models, Interpretations, and Theories: Constructing Explanations of Institutional Emergence and Change.” in *Explaining Social Institutions*. Jack Knight and Itai Sened, eds. Ann Arbor, MI: University of Michigan Press.

Class 2—March 8—Institutional Origins: Design and Function

1. Pierson, Paul (2000). “The Limits of Design: Explaining Institutional Origins and Change.” *Governance* Vol. 13 No. 4.

Week 10

Class 1—March 13—**Duke Spring Break** (**NO CLASS**)

Class 2—March 15—**Duke Spring Break** (**NO CLASS**)

Week 11

Class 1—March 20—Foot-binding and Female Genital Mutilation*

**Student-led discussions likely to begin. Readings in discussion weeks subject to change given student interest, class size, and topic interest.*

1. Mackie, Gerry (1996). “Ending Footbinding and Infibulation: A Convention Account.” *American Sociological Review* Vol. 61 No. 6.

Class 2—March 22—Marriage*

1. Cherlin, Andrew (2020). “Degrees of Change: An Assessment of the De-institutionalization of Marriage Thesis”. *Journal of Marriage and Family*. Vol. 82.
2. Ball, Molly (2019). “How Gay Marriage Became a Constitutional Right.” *The Atlantic*.

Week 12

Class 1—March 27—Institutionalizing Peace by Agreement*

1. Ruane, Joseph and Jennifer Todd (2007). “Path Dependence in Settlement Processes: Explaining Settlement in Northern Ireland.” *Political Studies*. Vol. 55.
2. Gidron, Benjamin, Stanley N. Katz and Yeheskel Hasenfeld (2002). “Northern Ireland.” in *Mobilizing For Peace: Conflict Resolution in Northern Ireland, Israel/Palestine and South Africa* Gidron, Katz and Hasenfeld, eds. New York: Oxford University Press. Selections.

Class 1—March 29—In Class Discussion of Assignment

1. **DUE:** The Institutional Context of the Problem
2. No readings.

Week 13

Class 1—April 3—Discussing *The Wire*, Episodes 5-8

1. Watch Season 1, Episodes 5-8 of *The Wire* by today.
2. No readings.

Class 2—April 5—How do institutions change?

1. Thelen, Kathleen and James Conran. “Institutional Change” in *the Oxford Handbook of Historical Institutionalism*.

Week 14

Class 1—April 10—How do norms change?

1. Bicchieri, Cristina (2017). *Norms in the Wild*. New York: Oxford University Press. **Chapters 3 and 4.**

Class 2—April 12—**Student Mental Health Day** (**NO CLASS**)

Week 15

Class 1—April 17—China’s Transition to Market Capitalism*

1. Lau, Lawrence, Yingui Qian and Gerard Roland (2000). “Reform without Losers.” *Journal of Political Economy*. Pages 1-4 only.
2. Qian, Yingyi (2000). “The Process of China’s Market Transition (1978-1998).” *Journal of Institutional and Theoretical Economics*.

Class 2—April 19—Corruption*

1. Persson, Anna, Bo Rothstein and Jan Teorell (2013). “Why Anticorruption Reforms Fail—Systemic Corruption as a Collective Action Problem.” *Governance*. Vol. 26, No. 3.
2. Mutebi, Alex M (2008). “Explaining the Failure of Thailand’s Anti-corruption Regime” *Development and Change* Vol. 39 No. 1.

Week 16

Class 1—April 24—The International Criminal Court*

1. Simmons, Beth A and Allison Danner (2010). “Credible Commitments and the International Criminal Court.” *International Organization*. Vol. 64.
2. How the ICC Works.

Class 2—April 26—Discussing *The Wire*, Episodes 9-13

1. Watch Season 1, Episodes 9-13 of *The Wire* by today.
2. No readings.